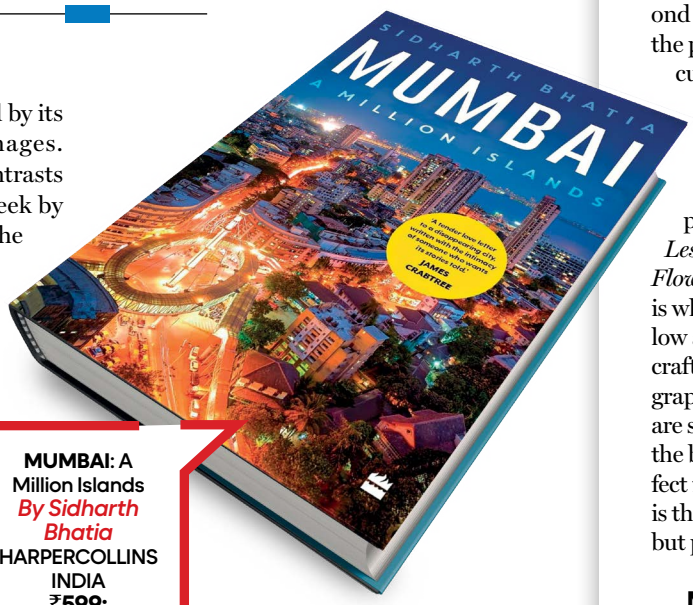
BOOKS ▼

GRIT BEHIND THE GLITZ

Mumbai: A Million Islands, by veteran journalist Sidharth Bhatia, reveals a city in the throes of rapid change and explores where it is headed



MUMBAI: A Million Islands
By Sidharth Bhatia
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹599; 312 pages

Mumbai is shackled by its stereotypical images. Fast. Chaotic. Contrasts that sit easily, cheek by jowl—slums and skyscrapers; the unemployed and billionaires; the citizens' attitudes of *chalta hai* as well as can-do; *jugaad* and professionalism; Marine Drive and Bollywood. The beleaguered city is trapped into these tropes as real-estate moguls and politicians use them freely to exploit weaknesses and fill their pockets. In *Mumbai: A Million Islands*, its author Sidharth Bhatia, one of the founding editors of *The Wire*, has trained his sharp journalistic eye on the city, revealing the real stories that make Mumbai what it is.

'Mumbai is upgrading' is a phrase that has haunted the city in recent times. Bhatia uses it as a fulcrum to explain how the city developed through the decades and to examine where it is going now. The author has spoken to a vast swathe of Mumbaikars, people far removed from the film stars or captains of industry whose words usually fill newspaper columns. Through these interviews and a deep understanding of the city's evolution, he shines a torch on parts of a Mumbai that many in the higher echelons suspect exist but would much rather ignore.

If you have the gumption, read about the many seemingly isolated 'islands' that mark modern-day Mumbai. Witness the dismal living conditions in the slums and in areas where victims of rapid redevelopment have been relegated to; follow the trajectory of our mill lands and ship-breaking yards; or ponder the impending fate of Kamathipura's red-light district. Bhatia backs up his narrative with facts and figures, and thorough research carried out by scouring old reports and other documents. While some parts of it could have benefited from better editing to reduce repetition, *Mumbai: A Million Islands* is a powerful book that absolutely must be read by anyone living in Mumbai or interested in urban development. ■

—Priya Pathiyan

THE LISTI

RECENT BOOK RELEASES THAT

Dark Blooms

Writer-photographer Buku Sarkar melds written and visual expression seamlessly in *My Dead Flowers*, the evocative second volume of Thayil Editions, the poetry series edited and curated by Jeet Thayil for HarperCollins' Fourth Estate India imprint. The book's title—which is also the title of one of the poems—echoes Baudelaire's *Les Fleurs du Mal* (*The Flowers of Evil*). The poetry is whimsical and warm, mellow and moody. Sarkar's subtly crafted black & white photographs, often featuring herself, are sprinkled judiciously across the book and provide the perfect foil to the written word. It is the destiny of flowers to wilt, but poetry, clearly, is not dead.

MY DEAD FLOWERS
Thayil Editions Book 2
By Buku Sarkar
HARPERCOLLINS/FOURTH ESTATE INDIA
₹499; 160 pages

